> consecrate the closing part of their lives to religion come hither to bathe and engage themselves in celibacy. This is also done by women, since it is related that the goddess once on a time resided at the place and bathed. From Komarei towards the south [*sic* – east] the country extends as far as Kolkhoi, where the fishing for pearls is carried out. Condemned criminals are employed in this service. King Pandion [i.e. Pandya] is the owner of the fishery.[4]

The famous *Tabula Peutingeriana* map of the Roman world, now housed in the National Library of Austria in Vienna, also has its origins in the first century with later additions, although what survives today is a medieval copy. The last folio of the map (discussed in detail in Chapter 6) shows India, with its southernmost cape marked as 'Comara'. The 'Comara', 'Komar' or 'Komarei' of the Romans is, of course, the 'Kumari' of the Indians, and from there it is only a short step to the Portuguese 'Cumerin' and on to the Comorin of our day.

So the goddess Kumari and her sisters most certainly predate the arrival of Brahminical Hinduism in what may be called the deep south. And here one name stands pre-eminent, head and shoulders above all others: Agastya. He is the rishi, or sage, credited with bringing the Sanskrit language to the South – and yet, paradoxically, this same sage Agastya is also claimed to be the man responsible for bringing the gift of the Tamil language.

A few miles north of Kanyakumari the very last of the peaks of the Western Ghats rise out of the plain. They are part of that same thickly forested mountain redoubt mentioned earlier that goes go by such names as the Tinnevelly Range, Pothigai Malai, Pothiyam Malai, Agastya Malai and Mahendra Giri, 'the hill of Mahendra'. This last has a particularly honoured place in Hindu tradition, taking its name from *maha*, 'great', and *Indra*, the Vedic rain god who